

FADE IN:

1. EXT. PRESTIGIOUS PRIVATE SCHOOL - SCHOOL COUNSELOR'S OFFICE - DAY

ETHAN MORRISON (17) sits rigidly in a plush armchair, designer blazer pressed despite a fresh split lip and bruised cheek. Across from him, DEREK CALDWELL (17) lounges casually, expensive polo pristine except for bloodied knuckles and a black eye, examining his nails with theatrical boredom.

SARAH CHEN (38), the school counselor, stands by her desk holding a file. Her professional attire can't mask the weariness in her eyes or the tremor in her hands as she sets down a coffee mug reading "World's #1 Mom."

SARAH

Gentlemen, your parents will be arriving shortly. I need to understand what happened between you two.

DEREK

What happened, Ms. Chen, is that golden boy here finally showed his true colors. Your father is going to lose everything he has built from zero. Your father's company is going to be ours. This could be news anytime.

ETHAN

(jaw tightening)

Your father owns this school, half of the city and tries to buy everything with ancestral money. What's something your father has built instead of buying from a better man? your father's been trying to destroy our business for months.

DEREK

Our business? You're seventeen. Your biggest accomplishment was getting kicked out of the football team for getting into a fight with me.

Derek steps closer, his black eye gleaming with malice.

DEREK (CONT'D)

Face it, Ethan. You're just another rich kid with anger issues, and deep down, you know your parents are ashamed of you.

Ethan lunges forward, but Sarah quickly interposes herself.

SARAH

Enough! Both of you, sit down. NOW. This is the third time you're sitting wounded in my office.

Both boys reluctantly return to their seats.

SARAH (CONT'D)

You two have every advantage in the world, and you're using it to tear each other apart.

The office door opens. VICTORIA MORRISON (45) enters, a striking woman in a tailored power suit, phone pressed to her ear.

VICTORIA

(into phone)

I don't care if Shanghai Team has concerns. The merger timeline doesn't change. Handle it.

She ends the call, surveying the scene with calculating eyes.

VICTORIA (CONT'D)

Ms. Chen, I'm Victoria Morrison. I assume you've documented the other boy's role in this incident?

ROBERT MORRISON (48) enters quietly behind her looking at his son.

ROBERT
Jesus, Ethan. Are you all right?

ETHAN
(not meeting his eyes)
I'm fine, Dad.

DEREK
(loudly)
Mr. Morrison! Derek Caldwell. My father sends his regards.

Robert's expression hardens at the name.

VICTORIA
What exactly happened here? Our legal team will need accurate documentation.

DEREK
(grinning despite his black eye)
Ethan here has quite the temper when someone mentions his family's... business practices.

ROBERT
(quietly to Ethan)
Son, what really happened?

Ethan finally looks up, his facade crumbling.

ETHAN
He talked shit about our business and when I tried to stop him he continued saying that you were ashamed of me. That I was just another disappointment you had to manage.

Robert's face goes pale.

VICTORIA
(sharply)
Robert, not here. What are the school's intentions regarding disciplinary action? I need to know if this will affect Ethan's college applications. He has a Princeton interview this week.

Sarah stares at Victoria with disbelief.

SARAH
Mrs. Morrison, your son has visible injuries and is clearly emotionally distressed. Aren't you concerned about his wellbeing at all?

VICTORIA
Of course. But what I'm concerned about is ensuring this incident doesn't derail his future prospects.

Derek laughs harshly.

DEREK
See, Ethan? Even your own mother cares more about your resume than your face.

ROBERT
That's enough from you, young man.

ETHAN
(barely audible)
I just wanted him to stop talking about you, Dad. About how we don't deserve what we have.

Robert kneels beside his son's chair.

ROBERT

Ethan, you never have to defend me. Not like this.

VICTORIA

(checking her watch)

This is touching, but I have a conference call with Tokyo. What do you need from us to resolve this?

SARAH

What I need is for these boys to understand that violence isn't the answer. What I need is for parents to show they care more about their children's wellbeing than their family's public image.

SARAH (CONT'D)

I see two young men with every material advantage, yet so emotionally starved they're beating each other bloody over their father's business disputes.

Victoria's phone rings. She reaches for it.

ROBERT

(firmly)

Victoria. Let it ring.

ROBERT (CONT'D)

(to Sarah)

You're right. I built my company so Ethan would never feel the insecurity I felt growing up. But I forgot that what he needed wasn't financial security—it was me.

ETHAN

(tears forming)

Dad, I know you work hard for us.

ROBERT

No, son. You're important. You're the most important thing in my life and I've done a terrible job of showing you that.

Derek watches this exchange, his smug expression fading.

DEREK

(quietly)

Must be nice to have a father who gives a damn.

ROBERT

Where is your father, Derek?

DEREK

(bitterly)

Busy. He sent his assistant to tell me he'd handle this 'appropriately'.

SARAH

(softly)

Derek, is that why you were baiting Ethan? Because you're angry at your own father?

DEREK

I'm tired of pretending that having money makes everything okay. Your dad talks to you. Mine communicates through lawyers and bank transfers.

ETHAN

But at least your dad doesn't expect you to be perfect all the time. Doesn't look at you like you're another acquisition that's not performing.

Victoria finally puts her phone away completely.

VICTORIA
(quietly)
I never intended to make Ethan feel like a disappointment.

ROBERT
But intentions don't matter if the impact is harmful.

He places both hands on Ethan's shoulders.

ROBERT (CONT'D)
Son, I'm proud of you. Not because of your grades, but because you're kind and you stand up for people you love.

ETHAN
I'm sorry I let you down, Dad.

ROBERT
You didn't let me down. I let you down by making you think you had to earn my love.

DEREK
Ms. Chen? Do you really think these things can get better?

SARAH
I've seen families rebuild from worse places. But it takes everyone being honest about their pain and responsibility.

VICTORIA
What would you recommend? For both boys?

SARAH
Family counseling. Individual therapy. And parents willing to prioritize their children's emotional needs over professional obligations.

Robert nods immediately. Victoria hesitates, then nods.

DEREK
And if my father won't participate?

ROBERT
Derek, if your father won't step up, i will. What happened between our companies doesn't have to define what happens between our sons.

Ethan stands and extends his hand to Derek.

ETHAN
I'm sorry I hit you. I shouldn't have tried to solve it with my fists.

Derek shakes it firmly.

DEREK
I'm sorry I was trying to hurt you. I was really trying to hurt myself, and you were just... convenient.

Victoria approaches Ethan, her corporate mask removed.

VICTORIA
Ethan, you are not a project or investment. You are my son, and you are enough exactly as you are.

She carefully touches his bruised cheek.

SARAH

There won't be any disciplinary action. But there will be follow-up. Weekly sessions, family counseling, regular check-ins.

SARAH (CONT'D)

Your children need you to show up. Not just financially, but emotionally.

Robert puts his arm around Ethan's shoulders—a genuine gesture of affection.

ROBERT

We'll be here. Whatever it takes.

DEREK

(quietly)

Thank you. All of you.

SARAH

Violence is never the answer. But sometimes it takes breaking something for people to realize how precious it really is.

The boys nod, understanding her meaning extends far beyond their physical fight.

FADE TO BLACK: